

RMS

| By Anand Natarajan |

There's much that is happening in Chennai to keep the rumour mills in overdrive. Muthuvel Karunanidhi and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) look invincible, but the chief minister is worried on two counts. His second wife, Rajathi, mother of Rajya Sabha MP Kanimozhi has been putting pressure for long on the patriarch to get a cabinet post for her daughter like he did for his elder son M.K. Azhagiri, who is currently the Union chemicals and fertilisers minister in the UPA Government. But it is her second demand that has reportedly infuriated the DMK chief. In an interview to a Tamil magazine, she said, "Karunanidhi should not, as he plans now, relinquish office in favour of his younger son M.K. Stalin, the deputy chief minister."

Karunanidhi's worries are compounded by the fact that his elder son finds common cause with his step-mother. Last week, the succession battle in the DMK appeared to have been reignited with the Azhagiri saying that he would not accept anyone other than his father as the party leader. Azhagiri knows very well that Stalin is a popular leader and nothing can stop him from succeeding his father unless the party itself splits. When asked about Azhagiri's latest salvo, an angry Karunanidhi shot back: "You better go and ask him". Observers now say the party will not need a Jayalalithaa to destroy it; Azhagiri would do it single-handedly.

Just 10 months ago, the suc-

cession row in the family appeared to have been settled with Azhagiri being sent to the Centre as a cabinet minister and Stalin assuming office as the deputy chief minister, the second father-son duo to hold the twin posts after the Badals of Punjab. The siblings have since then followed their different paths in politics and governance. While the elder brother is known to give scant regard to his duties as a Union minister, Stalin has been toiling hard to rebuild the party in the state. That is the way he has been ever since he joined the party's students' wing 40 years ago. Even today, he is known to keep 19-hour days, meeting people who come to him with grievances, replying to posts on his website or forwarding them to the relevant department for redressal. In Karunanidhi's absence, he takes over as leader of the House. "He has a clear political vision and acts efficiently. He has become an ideal, credible young leader," says DMK's literary wing secretary and poet Thamizhachi Thangapandian.

Karunanidhi had set a 2010 deadline for Stalin's succession as he wanted to retire after spending more than seven decades in state politics. But Stalin refuses to entertain the question. One doubts if Stalin will ever be made the chief minister. But his continuance will depend on various factors. In that sense, the last general elections served as a litmus test for him. The plight of Sri Lankan Tamils was a major issue and Karunanidhi couldn't participate actively in election campaign due to ill health. During those critical days, Stalin drew his own strategy and nullified the Opposition's attacks to register an astounding electoral victory, both in the Lok Sabha and by-elections.

Stalin's accession plans may not come true. His toughest challenge lies not just within the party but inside his family. Karunanidhi's loyal cadres and second-rung leaders are likely to obey their leader's command and accept Stalin as their leader. But within the party, elder brother Azhagiri and younger sister Kanimozhi nurse their own ambitions and have built their



(FROM LEFT) STALIN,
KARUNANIDHI
AND AZHAGIRI

THE SIBLING
RIVALRY IS
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